

States **JAMMU AND KASHMIR**

Valley of SLEAZE

Political discourse in the state touches a new low as Omar resigns and MLAs trade allegations of sexual misconduct

By Aijaz Hussain

If there is one thing that a politician is afraid of other than electoral defeat, it is scandal. And in the past week, Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) has had enough of it. Last Tuesday, the Congress and National Conference (NC)-led Government was rattled after Opposition leader and former deputy chief minister Muzaffar Hussain Baig alleged that Chief Minister Omar Abdullah was involved in the infamous 2006 Srinagar sex scandal. It involved several bureaucrats, politicians and senior police officials who were all caught, literally, with their pants down. The chief minister's initial reaction to this allegation was more emotional and knee-jerk: he threatened to resign. Later in the evening, Omar's stance had significantly transformed when he actually tendered a conditional resignation to Governor N.N. Vohra.

The buildup was swift and tasteless. On July 29, a MLA handed over a questionnaire to Assembly Speaker Mohammed Akbar Lone, who passed it on to Baig for his comments. Enraged by its contents which consisted of innuendos of Baig's alleged sexual peccadilloes, the former deputy chief minister tore up the questionnaire without responding to its contents. Amazingly enough Lone began to read out the questionnaire which sought to paint Baig as a man permanently on Viagra, dallying with friends'

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wives, neighbours and even an underage niece. With this accusation, political debate slipped to its lowest levels in recent times in the Valley. Earlier during the week, People's Democratic Party (PDP) leader Mehbooba Mufti had walked up to the podium and thrown away the Speaker's microphone, prompting Lone to order marshals to evict PDP MLAs from the House.

It was, however, Omar who shocked the state Assembly on July 28 when he left no room for himself to backtrack, turning on its head the accepted legal paradigm that a person is assumed innocent until proven guilty. "It's a blot on my character. I will consider myself guilty until proven innocent," he said in the Assembly that was meeting for what was his first budget session as the chief minister. But matters moved

rapidly after he left the House to meet party colleagues at his residence.

The drama began soon after Baig delivered a finely pre-scripted performance immediately after Zero Hour. He smoothly navigated from a general human rights scenario in the state to the almost forgotten three-year-old Srinagar sex scandal. Addressing the House, Baig had even the Treasury Benches nodding gently in approval when he asked: "Didn't that sex scandal also bring down your heads in shame?" Then he dropped the bombshell as he pulled out a list he claimed originated from the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) which contained the junior Abdullah's name as one of the politicians allegedly involved in the sex scandal. "I'll not read the whole list. At number 102 is the name of Omar

